

Wins & Highlights

2026

January

At Bitcoin Park in Austin, HRF's first AI Hack for Freedom paired eight dissidents from Venezuela, Russia, China, and beyond with top open-source developers to build tools for activists through vibe coding. Due to the success, three more followed throughout the year.



April

Nine Freedom Fellows received 30+ hours of training at a working retreat in Brussels and met the European Parliament's Subcommittee on Human Rights.

HRF hosted three days of "Freedom Go Up" programming at Bitcoin 2026 in Las Vegas with Jeff Booth, Anaïse Kanimba, Lisa Neigut, Matt Odell, and Farida Nabourema, plus a mainstage panel with Evan Mawarire and Srdja Popović.



May

After its Miami Beach debut, HRF's "Doors to Freedom" public art installation stood in Rådhusplassen, one of Oslo's busiest public squares, in the run-up to OFF — introducing eight persecuted artists to a mass audience.



Jan.

Feb.

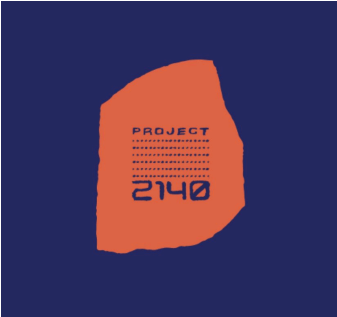
March

April

May

January

More than 50 activists and developers gathered in Nosara, Costa Rica for Project 2140, stress-testing Bitcoin's governance risks, scaling trade-offs, and decentralization. At the gathering, Andreas M. Antonopoulos was announced as the Finney Freedom Prize laureate — awarded with the Finney family for foundational contributions to Bitcoin education and self-custody.



February

HRF publicly launched the Tyranny Tracker, its global democracy index, before 229 attendees at the Freedom Tower in New York — featuring Francis Fukuyama — classifying 179 countries and territories.

HRF launched Agent Camps, an initiative where the world's most prominent human rights defenders learn to deploy and use their own open-source personal agents to supercharge their work.



March

HRF privately urged Doja Cat to cancel her Move Afrika concert in Kigali, then made the letter public, calling out a regime that restricts Rwandan artists and backs atrocities in eastern Congo. The post drew nearly 400,000 views on X.

Sports & Dictators lead Karim Zidan won the J. Anthony Lukas Work-in-Progress Award for his forthcoming book "In the Shadow of the Cage," on mixed martial arts and strongman politics.



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June 1–3

The 2026 Oslo Freedom Forum gathered nearly 1,600 participants from 111 countries under the theme "Dismantling Dictatorship." Nobel Peace Prize laureate María Corina Machado addressed the forum in person for the first time.



August 8–15

Twenty frontline defenders gathered at Blue Spirit in Nosara, Costa Rica, for HRF's first Resilience Retreat — a trauma-informed week of rest and peer support marking the launch of HRF's newest program.



October

The Global Freedom Tech Summit returned to Nashville (Oct. 6–9) which brought technologists, activists, philanthropists, and educators together to discuss how technology can be used to accelerate freedom.



June

July

Aug.

Sept.

Oct.

Nov.

Dec.

July 4

Pastor Ezra Jin, founder of one of China's largest underground house churches, was released after 266 days in detention, following HRF's UN petition and a campaign amplified to more than 650 Congressional staffers ahead of President Trump's meeting with Xi Jinping, who raised the case directly.

June–August

"Power Plays," Karim Zidan's five-part podcast on the World Cup and authoritarianism, became the most popular podcast HRF has ever launched — 100,000+ downloads and a featured spot on Apple Podcasts' homepage.



September

With the National Endowment for Democracy, HRF brought ten leading defenders to Washington, D.C. for Agent Camp VII — followed by the third AI Hack for Freedom and Freedom Tech DC. The College Freedom Forum came to Europe for the first time on Sept. 25 in Berlin.



November

The second AI for Individual Rights Summit convened in San Francisco (Nov. 3–5) which gathered AI industry leaders, human rights defenders, researchers, and community leaders to learn how AI can serve as a tool for freedom.

